Referencing Made Easy

APA, MLA and Chicago Citation Guide

A Thesis Guide

Darkhan Mentor

2026

Abstract

Every thesis and research paper is built on the work of others, and referencing is the system by which a writer shows what has been borrowed, where it came from, and how the reader can find it. A paper without references asks the reader to take every claim on trust. A paper with clear, consistent references invites the reader to check every claim, and that invitation is the foundation of academic trust. Yet referencing is the part of academic writing that students fear most, because it seems to be a mass of small rules about commas, italics, and capital letters, with a different set of rules for every subject.

This guide makes referencing simple by treating it as one skill with three main systems. It explains why referencing matters and what happens when it is done badly. It explains the two parts of every referencing system, the short citation in the text and the full entry in the list at the end, and how the two parts connect. It then explains the three systems students are most likely to meet: APA (7th edition), used widely in the social sciences, education, and business; MLA (9th edition), used widely in literature, languages, and the humanities; and Chicago (17th edition), used in history and many other humanities subjects, in two forms, notes and bibliography, and author-date. Each system is explained with worked examples for the sources students cite most often: books, journal articles, chapters, theses, and websites.

Later chapters cover choosing the right style for a subject, citing unusual sources such as interviews and datasets, the difference between paraphrasing and quoting, avoiding plagiarism, using reference management software, and the most common errors, with a checklist for the final check before submission. The examples in this guide use fictional authors and titles so that no real publication is misrepresented, and the guide states only the well-established rules of each style. For fine details, the official manual of the required style remains the final authority. By the end of the guide, a student should be able to cite any common source correctly, keep a reference list consistent, and submit a thesis whose referencing an examiner can trust.

Keywords: referencing; citation; APA 7th edition; MLA 9th edition; Chicago 17th edition; plagiarism

Table of Contents

Abstract	2
1. Why Referencing Matters	3
2. In-Text Citations and Reference Lists	5
3. APA 7th Edition in Detail	7
4. MLA 9th Edition in Detail	9
5. Chicago 17th Edition: Two Systems	11
6. Choosing the Right Style for Your Field	13
7. Citing Books, Articles, Chapters, Theses and Websites	15
8. Citing Unusual Sources	17
9. Paraphrasing and Quoting	20
10. Avoiding Plagiarism	21
11. Reference Managers	23
12. Common Errors and a Checklist	25
13. Worked Examples	26
14. Conclusion	29
Suggested Reading	29

How to use this guide: read Chapters 1 and 2 first, to understand what referencing is and how its two parts fit together. Then read the chapter for the style your department requires: Chapter 3 for APA, Chapter 4 for MLA, or Chapter 5 for Chicago. Use Chapters 7 and 8 as a look-up reference while you write, and work through Chapters 9 to 12 before you submit.

Chapter 1: Why Referencing Matters

Referencing is the practice of acknowledging the sources of ideas, words, data, and arguments that a writer has used from other people. Every time a thesis states a fact, reports a finding, or uses an idea that came from someone else, a reference tells the reader where that material came from. Without references, a thesis is a set of claims with no evidence trail, and the reader has no way to tell which ideas are the writer's own and which have been borrowed.

Referencing matters for three reasons. The first is honesty. Research is a conversation across time: each new study builds on earlier studies, and referencing is how a writer shows respect for the people whose work made their own possible. The second is evidence. A claim that is referenced can be checked; a claim that is not referenced can only be believed or disbelieved. The third is usefulness. A good reference list is a map of the field: a reader who wants to learn more about a topic can follow the references to the most important books and articles. A thesis with a careful reference list is therefore useful even to a reader who disagrees with its

conclusions.

1.1 What referencing does for the reader

Consider a reader who meets a surprising claim in a thesis: for example, that a particular teaching method improves test scores. The reader's first question is: whose finding is this? If the claim carries a citation, the reader can look up the original study, check how many students took part, see whether the result has been repeated, and decide how much weight to give it. If the claim carries no citation, the reader must either trust the writer completely or dismiss the claim entirely. Neither response is good scholarship.

Referencing also helps the reader to judge the quality of the writer's work. An examiner who reads a thesis looks at the reference list to see whether the writer has read the important literature, whether the sources are recent and relevant, and whether the writer has understood them. A reference list full of old, irrelevant, or low-quality sources tells the examiner that the literature review is weak, even before the chapters are read. A reference list that is careful, current, and well chosen is evidence of a careful mind.

1.2 What referencing does for the writer

Referencing protects the writer as well as the reader. A writer who cites sources properly can show that an idea came from elsewhere, and can therefore defend themselves against any suggestion that they claimed someone else's work as their own. Referencing also strengthens the writer's argument: a claim supported by published evidence is far more persuasive than the same claim standing alone. The strongest theses are those in which every important claim is anchored to evidence, and the references are the anchors.

There is also a practical benefit. A writer who records full details of every source as they read, and who formats references consistently from the start, saves hours of frantic work at the end of the project. A writer who leaves referencing until the last week must hunt through notes, search for missing page numbers, and reformat a hundred entries under pressure. That is how errors happen, and errors in referencing are among the easiest faults for an examiner to spot.

1.3 The cost of getting it wrong

Poor referencing has real consequences. At the mild end, inconsistent or incomplete references lose marks and irritate examiners, who may conclude that the writer is careless in other areas too. In the middle, a missing citation for a borrowed idea may be treated as poor academic practice and require correction before the thesis is accepted. At the serious end, presenting someone else's words or ideas as one's own is plagiarism, and it can lead to failure of the thesis, loss of a degree, or damage to a career. Chapter 10 explains plagiarism in detail; the point here is that referencing is not a formality. It is the mechanism that keeps academic work honest.

Worked Example: A claim with and without a reference

Without a reference: 'Peer feedback improves writing accuracy.' The reader cannot tell

whether this is the writer's finding, a widely known fact, or someone else's result. With a reference: 'Peer feedback improves writing accuracy (Ahmad, 2021).' The reader now knows whose finding this is, can look up the study, and can judge whether the claim is justified. One short citation changes an unsupported assertion into a checkable claim. (Author and year are fictional, for illustration only.)

[ ] I can explain in one sentence why referencing matters.

[ ] I understand that a reference lets the reader check a claim.

[ ] I will record the full details of every source as I read it.

[ ] I know that poor referencing can cost marks and, at worst, a degree.

Chapter 2: In-Text Citations and Reference Lists

Every referencing system has two parts that work together: a short citation in the text, placed where the borrowed material is used, and a full entry in a list at the end of the document, giving the complete details of the source. The in-text citation is a pointer; the list entry is the destination. The reader follows the pointer to the list, and from the list to the source itself. If either part is missing, or if the two parts do not match, the system breaks.

The in-text citation is short because it must not interrupt the reading. In APA and Chicago author-date, it usually gives the author's surname and the year of publication, and sometimes a page number. In MLA, it gives the author's surname and a page number. In Chicago notes and bibliography, it is a footnote or an endnote with a number in the text. The reader who wants the full details turns to the list at the end. The list is alphabetical by the author's surname, so that any citation can be found quickly.

2.1 The in-text citation

An in-text citation is placed at the end of the sentence or clause that uses the borrowed material, before the full stop in most styles. Its job is to name the source, not to describe it. 'Ahmad (2021) found that...' and 'Peer feedback improves accuracy (Ahmad, 2021)' are both correct in APA style; they differ only in whether the author's name is part of the sentence. The choice is a matter of style and emphasis, and a good writer varies it: naming the author in the sentence gives the author prominence, while putting the citation in brackets keeps the focus on the finding.

A citation must be attached to the claim it supports. If a paragraph draws on three sources, it needs three citations, placed next to the claims they support. A single citation at the end of a long paragraph does not tell the reader which sentences it covers, and an examiner may reasonably ask whether the uncited sentences are the writer's own ideas or borrowed ones. When in doubt, cite. It is better to cite one time too many than one time too few.

2.2 The reference list

The reference list, called 'References' in APA, 'Works Cited' in MLA, and 'Bibliography'

in Chicago notes and bibliography, gives the full details of every source cited in the text. Each entry gives the author, the year, the title, and the publication details, in an order and a format fixed by the style. The list is arranged alphabetically by the first author's surname, and it is double-spaced with a hanging indent in most styles, so that the author's name stands out at the start of each entry.

Three rules govern the list. First, every source cited in the text must appear in the list. Second, every entry in the list must be cited in the text, with the exception of a Chicago bibliography, which may include sources consulted but not cited. Third, the details in the list must match the details in the text: the same spelling of the author's name, the same year, the same title. A mismatch between the two parts is one of the commonest errors in student theses, and one of the easiest for an examiner to find.

Part	Where it appears	What it contains	Example (APA)
In-text citation	In the sentence	Author and year	(Ahmad, 2021)
Reference list entry	End of the document	Full publication details	Ahmad, S. (2021). Title of the book. Publisher.

Note that the example above is a pattern, not a real publication. The author's name and the title are invented to show the shape of an entry. Real entries use the real details of real sources, copied carefully from the title page of the book or the first page of the article.

2.3 The two-part check

Before submitting any piece of work, perform the two-part check. Read through the text and list every citation you find. Then read through the reference list and tick off each citation. Any citation without a matching entry, and any entry without a matching citation, must be fixed. Reference management software can do this check automatically, as Chapter 11 explains, but a manual check is still worth doing, because software can only check what it has been given.

[ ] Every claim drawn from a source carries an in-text citation.

[ ] Every in-text citation has a matching entry in the reference list.

[ ] Every entry in the reference list is cited in the text.

[ ] The author's name and year match between the citation and the list entry.

[ ] The reference list is in alphabetical order by the first author's surname.

Chapter 3: APA 7th Edition in Detail

APA style, published by the American Psychological Association, is the most widely used referencing system in the social sciences, education, business, and many health fields. Its current edition is the 7th, and it is an author-date system: the in-text citation gives the author's surname and the year, and the reference list gives the full details. The system's strength is its clarity and its consistency. Once a writer has learned its basic patterns, almost every source can be cited by following the same few rules.

APA style is not only a referencing system; it is a complete guide to writing, covering headings, tables, figures, and the overall format of a paper. This chapter covers the referencing rules that matter most to a thesis writer: in-text citations, the reference list, and the common source types. For formatting questions beyond referencing, the official APA Publication Manual is the authority, and a writer should consult it rather than guess.

3.1 In-text citations in APA

An APA in-text citation gives the author's surname and the year of publication. For a work by one author, the citation is (Ahmad, 2021). For a work by two authors, both surnames are given: (Ahmad and Khan, 2021). For a work by three or more authors, only the first author's surname is given, followed by the Latin abbreviation 'et al.', meaning 'and others': (Ahmad et al., 2021). The same rule applies every time the work is cited, including the first time, which is a change from earlier editions of APA.

When the author's name is part of the sentence, only the year goes in brackets: 'Ahmad (2021) found that peer feedback improved accuracy.' When the author is not named in the sentence, both the name and the year go in brackets: 'Peer feedback improved accuracy (Ahmad, 2021).' A page number is added for a direct quotation, and it is also helpful for a paraphrase of a specific passage: (Ahmad, 2021, p. 45). For a quotation of fewer than forty words, the quotation is run into the text with double quotation marks; longer quotations are set as a separate block, indented, without quotation marks.

3.2 The reference list in APA

The APA reference list is headed 'References', and entries are arranged alphabetically by the first author's surname. Each entry begins with the author's surname followed by initials, then the year in brackets, then the title, then the publication details. Book titles and journal titles are written in italics; article titles are written in plain text, with only the first word and proper nouns capitalised. This capitalisation rule, called sentence case, is one of the most distinctive features of APA style, and it is also one of the most often forgotten.

For a book, the entry gives the author, the year, the title in italics, and the publisher. For a journal article, it gives the author, the year, the article title, the journal title in italics, the volume number in italics, the issue number in brackets, the page range, and the DOI (digital object identifier) where one is available. The DOI is a permanent

link to the article, and APA style prefers it to a general web address. For a source without a DOI, a web address may be given instead.

3.3 Common APA patterns

Most sources a student cites fall into a small number of patterns, and learning those patterns covers the great majority of referencing. A book with one author, a journal article, a chapter in an edited book, and a web page together account for most entries in a typical thesis reference list. Chapter 7 gives the patterns for each of these source types in all three styles, so that they can be compared side by side.

Two APA rules deserve special attention because students often get them wrong. First, when a work has more than twenty authors, the reference list entry gives the first nineteen, then an ellipsis, then the final author; the in-text citation still uses the first author with 'et al.'. Second, when a source has no author, the title moves to the author's position, both in the text and in the list. When a source has no date, the abbreviation 'n.d.' (no date) is used in place of the year.

Worked Example: APA in-text citations (fictional authors)

One author: 'Peer feedback improved accuracy (Ahmad, 2021).' Two authors: 'The effect was larger in small classes (Ahmad and Khan, 2021).' Three or more authors: 'Similar results were reported in three schools (Ahmad et al., 2021).' Direct quotation: 'Ahmad (2021) states that feedback works best when it is specific and timely (p. 45).' Note the pattern: the surname and the year are always present, and the page number appears only where a specific passage is quoted or referred to.

Situation	In-text citation (APA)
One author	(Ahmad, 2021)
Two authors	(Ahmad and Khan, 2021)
Three or more authors	(Ahmad et al., 2021)
Author named in the sentence	Ahmad (2021)
Direct quotation	(Ahmad, 2021, p. 45)
No author	Use the title in place of the author
No date	(Ahmad, n.d.)

- [ ] In-text citations give surname and year, with 'et al.' for three or more authors.
- [ ] Page numbers are given for direct quotations.
- [ ] The list is headed 'References' and is in alphabetical order.
- [ ] Book and journal titles are in italics; article titles use sentence case.
- [ ] A DOI is given for journal articles where one is available.

Chapter 4: MLA 9th Edition in Detail

MLA style, published by the Modern Language Association, is the standard referencing system in literature, languages, cultural studies, and many other humanities subjects. Its current edition is the 9th. Unlike APA, MLA is an author-page system: the in-text citation gives the author's surname and the page number, but not the year. The emphasis on the page reflects the way humanities scholars work, quoting and discussing specific passages of texts rather than reporting the year a study was published.

MLA style is built around a simple idea: a reference should give the reader the information needed to find the source, in a standard order, using a small set of core elements. Those elements are the author, the title of the source, the title of the container, other contributors, the version, the number, the publisher, the publication date, and the location. Not every source has all nine elements, but the order is always the same, and that consistency makes the system easy to learn once the pattern is understood.

4.1 In-text citations in MLA

An MLA in-text citation gives the author's surname and the page number, in brackets, at the end of the sentence: (Ahmad 45). Note that there is no comma between the name and the page number, and no year. If the author's name is given in the sentence, only the page number goes in brackets: 'Ahmad argues that feedback works best when it is specific (45).' If the work has no page numbers, as with many web sources, only the author's name is given.

For a work by two authors, both surnames are given: (Ahmad and Khan 45). For a work by three or more authors, the first author's surname is followed by 'et al.': (Ahmad et al. 45). For a work with no author, the title is used instead, shortened if it is long: ('Short Title' 45). For a quotation, the citation follows the closing quotation mark, and the full stop comes after the bracket. Poetry and drama have special rules: poems are cited by line number, and plays by act, scene, and line.

4.2 The Works Cited list in MLA

The MLA list is headed 'Works Cited', and entries are arranged alphabetically by the author's surname. Each entry gives the author's name in full, surname first, then the title of the source in italics if it is a book or a journal, or in quotation marks if it is an article, a chapter, or a poem. Then comes the container: the journal, the edited book, or the website in which the source appears, in italics, followed by the publisher, the date, and the location, which is usually a page range or a DOI or web address.

A distinctive feature of MLA is its capitalisation: titles use title case, meaning that the main words are capitalised, which is the opposite of APA's sentence case. Another distinctive feature is the treatment of the publication date: MLA gives the date near the end of the entry, in day-month-year order, and it does not put the year in brackets after the author's name. These small differences are exactly the details that an examiner checks, and a writer who mixes APA and MLA conventions in the same

list will be marked down for inconsistency.

4.3 Common MLA patterns

The most common MLA entries are a book, an article in a journal, a chapter in an edited book, and a page on a website. In each case the same core elements appear in the same order, and the writer's job is to fill in the elements that the source has and to leave out the ones it does not. A book has an author, a title, a publisher, and a year. A journal article has an author, an article title, a journal title, a volume and issue number, a year, and a page range. A web page has an author where one is known, a page title, a website title, a publisher or sponsor, a date, and a web address.

MLA 9th edition made one change that students should know: it gives more guidance on citing online sources, including the use of DOIs and stable web addresses, and it advises writers to include the date of access only when the source is likely to change, such as a web page that is updated regularly. For most sources, the date of access is not needed.

Worked Example: MLA in-text citations (fictional authors)

One author: 'Feedback works best when it is specific and timely (Ahmad 45).' Author named in the sentence: 'Ahmad argues that feedback works best when it is specific (45).' Two authors: 'The effect was larger in small classes (Ahmad and Khan 112).' Three or more authors: 'Similar results were reported in three schools (Ahmad et al. 78).' Note the pattern: the surname and the page number are always present, there is no comma between them, and there is no year.

Situation	In-text citation (MLA)
One author	(Ahmad 45)
Two authors	(Ahmad and Khan 112)
Three or more authors	(Ahmad et al. 78)
Author named in the sentence	(45)
No author	Use the title: ('Short Title' 45)
No page number	(Ahmad)

- [ ] In-text citations give surname and page number, with no comma and no year.
- [ ] The list is headed 'Works Cited' and is in alphabetical order.
- [ ] Book and journal titles are in italics; article titles are in quotation marks.
- [ ] Titles use title case, with the main words capitalised.
- [ ] A DOI or stable web address is given for online sources.

Chapter 5: Chicago 17th Edition: Two Systems

Chicago style, published by the University of Chicago Press, is unusual in offering two complete referencing systems in one manual. The first is notes and bibliography, used widely in history, literature, and the arts. The second is author-date, used widely in the sciences and social sciences. A writer must know which of the two systems their department requires, because the two systems look very different on the page, even though they give the same information. This chapter explains both, and shows how to choose between them.

The current edition of the manual is the 17th. Both systems are described in it, and both are accepted in academic writing. The notes and bibliography system is the older of the two, and it is the one most readers associate with the name Chicago. The author-date system was added later, for writers in fields where the year of publication matters more than the page. A thesis should use one system throughout, and never mix the two.

5.1 Notes and bibliography

In the notes and bibliography system, a citation in the text is a small raised number, called a superscript number, placed at the end of the sentence. The number refers to a note at the bottom of the page, called a footnote, or at the end of the document, called an endnote. The note gives the full details of the source the first time it is cited, and a shortened form on later citations. At the end of the document, a bibliography lists all the sources, in alphabetical order, in a slightly different format from the notes.

A first note for a book gives the author's full name in normal order, the title in italics, the publication details in brackets, and the page number: a reader who follows the note can find the source without turning to the bibliography. A later note for the same source gives only the author's surname, a shortened title, and the page number. This system has two advantages: the text is not interrupted by brackets, and the notes can carry extra explanation or comment that would not fit in the text. Its disadvantage is that it takes more space and more care to keep the numbers, the notes, and the bibliography in agreement.

5.2 Author-date

In the Chicago author-date system, the in-text citation gives the author's surname, the year, and the page number where relevant, in brackets: (Ahmad 2021, 45). The reference list, headed 'References', gives the full details in alphabetical order, in a format very close to APA style. The main differences from APA are small but real: the year is not in brackets in the reference list, and the overall style of punctuation differs in detail. A writer who knows APA can learn Chicago author-date quickly, but must not assume the two systems are identical.

The author-date system is preferred in fields where the date of a study matters, because the year is visible in the text. It is also easier to produce with reference management software, because the citations are simple brackets rather than

numbered notes. Its disadvantage is that a text with many citations can become cluttered with brackets, and a reader who wants the full details must turn to the end of the document.

5.3 Comparing the two systems

The choice between the two systems is made by the department or the journal, not by the writer. History and literature usually require notes and bibliography, because those fields value the extra space for comment that footnotes provide, and because their sources are often old books and archival documents for which a page reference matters more than a year. The sciences and many social sciences prefer author-date, because the year shows at a glance how recent the evidence is.

Whatever the system, the principle is the same: the reader must be able to find the source. A footnote that gives the author, the title, and the page is as useful as a reference list entry that gives the same information. The writer's job is to follow the chosen system consistently, and to check that every note has a matching entry in the bibliography, and that every entry is cited in the notes or in the text.

Worked Example: Chicago notes and bibliography (fictional authors)

First note for a book: '1. Sara Ahmad, The Craft of Feedback (Lahore: City Press, 2021), 45.' Later note for the same book: '2. Ahmad, The Craft of Feedback, 52.' Bibliography entry: 'Ahmad, Sara. The Craft of Feedback. Lahore: City Press, 2021.' Note the differences: the note gives the author's name in normal order and the publication details in brackets, while the bibliography entry gives the surname first and the publication details without brackets. Both give the same information in a different order.

Feature	Notes and bibliography	Author-date
Citation in the text	Raised number	(Ahmad 2021, 45)
Full details appear in	Footnote and bibliography	Reference list
Year visible in the text?	No	Yes
Common in	History, literature, arts	Sciences, social sciences
List heading	Bibliography	References

[ ] I know which Chicago system my department requires, and I use only that one.

[ ] In notes and bibliography, every number in the text has a matching note.

[ ] First notes are complete; later notes are shortened.

[ ] In author-date, citations give surname, year and page.

[ ] The bibliography or reference list is in alphabetical order.

Chapter 6: Choosing the Right Style for Your Field

Students are often told to use a particular referencing style without being told why, and the result is that the style feels arbitrary, a set of rules imposed for no reason. In fact, each style exists because it suits the way a particular field works. APA suits fields where the year of a study matters, because findings change quickly. MLA suits fields where the exact words and the exact page matter, because scholars discuss passages of texts. Chicago notes and bibliography suits fields where sources are varied and commentary is valued. Understanding why a style is used makes it far easier to follow.

The rule for choosing a style is simple: use the style your department, your supervisor, or your journal requires. If no style is specified, choose the style that is standard in your field, and use it consistently. Never mix styles in one document, and never change styles halfway through a thesis. Consistency matters more than the choice itself: an examiner will forgive a writer for using APA where MLA was expected far more readily than for mixing the two.

6.1 Styles by field

In education, psychology, business, economics, and the health sciences, APA is the usual choice. Its author-date citations show at a glance how recent the evidence is, which matters in fields where knowledge changes quickly. In literature, languages, and cultural studies, MLA is the usual choice. Its author-page citations point the reader to the exact passage under discussion, which matters in fields where the text itself is the evidence.

In history, Chicago notes and bibliography is the usual choice, because historians work with a wide range of sources, including archives and old documents, and because footnotes give space for the extra detail those sources need. In many other humanities subjects, either MLA or Chicago notes and bibliography may be required, and the department will specify which. In the natural sciences, styles vary by journal, and many journals have their own numbered systems; a science student should follow the instructions of the journal or the department rather than choosing a style at random.

6.2 When the rules are unclear

No guide can cover every source, and a student will eventually meet a source that does not fit any pattern in this book: a government report with no named author, a web page with no date, a dataset, a personal interview. In such cases, the principle is more important than the pattern. Give the reader enough information to find the source: the author or organisation, the title, the date, and the place where the source can be found. Follow the general pattern of the chosen style as closely as possible,

and be consistent.

When a detail is genuinely missing, say so in the way the style prescribes: 'n.d.' for no date in APA, or the title in place of the author where no author is given. Do not invent a detail to fill the gap. An invented author or an invented date is worse than a missing one, because it sends the reader to a source that does not exist. Chapter 8 gives guidance on the unusual sources students meet most often.

Field	Usual style	Why it suits the field
Education, psychology, business	APA 7th	Year shows how recent the evidence is
Literature, languages	MLA 9th	Page points to the exact passage
History	Chicago notes and bibliography	Footnotes suit varied sources
Sciences, social sciences	Chicago author-date or APA	Year visible in the text
Health sciences	APA 7th	Standard across the field

These are common patterns, not laws. Departments differ, journals differ, and individual supervisors have preferences. The department's handbook and the supervisor's advice always come before any general table, including this one.

[ ] I know which style my department requires, and I have it in writing.

[ ] I understand why that style suits my field.

[ ] I use one style throughout the whole document.

[ ] When a source does not fit a pattern, I give enough detail for the reader to find it.

[ ] I never invent a missing detail such as an author or a date.

Chapter 7: Citing Books, Articles, Chapters, Theses and Websites

Five kinds of source account for most of the entries in a typical thesis reference list: books, journal articles, chapters in edited books, theses, and websites. Learn to cite these five correctly, and the great majority of referencing is done. This chapter gives the pattern for each kind in APA, MLA, and Chicago author-date, so that the three styles can be compared directly. The examples use fictional authors and titles, so that no real publication is misrepresented; the patterns, not the names, are what matter.

The same principles apply to all five kinds. Record the author's name exactly as it appears on the source. Record the title exactly, including any subtitle. Record the publication details from the title page of a book or the first page of an article, not from a library catalogue or a search result, which may abbreviate or alter them. And record the details as you read, not at the end of the project, when the source may be hard to find again.

7.1 Books

A book entry needs four things: the author, the year or date, the title, and the publisher. In APA, the entry reads: surname, initials, year in brackets, title in italics in sentence case, publisher. In MLA, it reads: surname, first name, title in italics in title case, publisher, year. In Chicago author-date, it reads: surname, first name, year, title in italics, place of publication, publisher. The differences are in the order, the punctuation, and the capitalisation, not in the information given.

An edited book has an editor rather than an author, and the entry says so: in APA, the editor's name is followed by '(Ed.)'; in MLA, by 'editor'; in Chicago, by 'edited by'. A book in a later edition states the edition number, because the content may have changed. A translated book names the translator. These details are small, but they are part of giving the reader enough information to find the exact source that was used.

7.2 Journal articles

A journal article entry needs the author, the year, the article title, the journal title, the volume and issue numbers, the page range, and the DOI where one exists. The journal title is always in italics, and the volume number is in italics in APA and Chicago. The article title is in plain text in APA, in quotation marks in MLA, and in plain text with title case in Chicago author-date. The DOI is a permanent identifier, and it should be given as a full web address in current APA and MLA style, so that the reader can click it and reach the article.

Journal articles are the most commonly cited source in most theses, and they are also the source most often cited incorrectly. The commonest errors are: omitting the volume or issue number, giving the wrong page range, and confusing the journal title with the article title. Check each of these three details against the first page of the

article before submitting.

7.3 Chapters in edited books

A chapter in an edited book is cited as a part of a larger work, and the entry must name both the chapter and the book. In APA, the entry gives the chapter author, the year, the chapter title, the word 'In', the editors' names, the book title in italics, the page range of the chapter, and the publisher. In MLA, the chapter title is in quotation marks, the book title is in italics, and the editors are named after the book title. In Chicago, the pattern is similar, with the editor named and the page range given.

The page range of the chapter is essential, because it tells the reader where the chapter begins and ends in the book. Without it, the reader must search the whole book. The editor's name is also essential, because the same book title may have been published in more than one edition with different editors.

7.4 Theses and dissertations

A thesis or dissertation is cited like a book, with the addition of the degree, the university, and the fact that it is unpublished or published. In APA, an unpublished thesis gives the author, the year, the title in italics, the words 'Unpublished doctoral dissertation' or 'Unpublished master's thesis', and the university. In MLA, the entry gives the author, the title in quotation marks, the year, and the university, with the degree stated. In Chicago, the entry gives the author, the title in quotation marks, the degree and the university, and the year.

Many theses are now available online through a university repository, and in that case a web address or a stable link should be given, so that the reader can read the thesis itself. A thesis that is only available in print should be cited with the university and the year, so that the reader can request it through a library.

7.5 Websites and web pages

A web page entry needs the author where one is known, the date of publication or of the last update, the title of the page, the title of the website, and the web address. In APA, the entry gives the author, the date in brackets, the page title in italics in sentence case, the site name, and the address. In MLA, the page title is in quotation marks, the site title is in italics, and the publisher or sponsor is named. In Chicago author-date, the pattern is similar to APA, with the date placed after the author's name.

Web pages cause more trouble than any other source, because they often have no named author, no clear date, and no stable address. When no author is given, use the organisation responsible for the site as the author. When no date is given, use 'n.d.' in APA, or omit the date in MLA and Chicago and give the date of access if the style requires it. When a page is likely to change, such as a news page or a statistics page, give the date on which it was accessed. Do not cite a web page by its address alone; an address without a title, an author, and a date is not a reference.

Worked Example: One source, three styles (fictional book)

APA: Ahmad, S. (2021). The craft of feedback. City Press. MLA: Ahmad, Sara. The Craft of

Feedback. City Press, 2021. Chicago author-date: Ahmad, Sara. 2021. The Craft of Feedback. Lahore: City Press. The same information appears in all three entries: the author, the year, the title, and the publisher. Only the order, the punctuation, and the capitalisation change. A writer who understands this can move between styles without relearning the principles.

Source type	Key details needed
Book	Author, year, title, publisher
Journal article	Author, year, article title, journal, volume, issue, pages, DOI
Chapter in edited book	Chapter author, year, chapter title, editors, book title, pages, publisher
Thesis	Author, year, title, degree, university
Website	Author or organisation, date, page title, site title, web address

[ ] I can cite a book, an article, a chapter, a thesis and a web page in my chosen style.

[ ] Publication details are copied from the source itself, not from a search result.

[ ] Journal entries include the volume, issue, page range and DOI where available.

[ ] Chapter entries include the editors, the book title and the page range.

[ ] Web entries include an author or organisation, a date, and a web address.

Chapter 8: Citing Unusual Sources

Most sources fit the patterns in Chapter 7, but a thesis will usually contain a few that do not. Interviews, datasets, government reports, conference papers, newspapers, films, and social media posts all need references, and each has its own pattern. This chapter covers the unusual sources students meet most often. The guiding principle is the same as ever: give the reader enough information to find the source, in the order and the format of the chosen style, and do not invent details that are missing.

Unusual sources are also the sources most often cited badly, for two reasons. First, students do not know the pattern, so they guess, and the guess is usually wrong. Second, some unusual sources are difficult to find again, so the writer cites them from memory and gets the details wrong. The remedy is to record the details at the moment the source is used, and to check the pattern in the official manual or in this chapter before writing the entry.

8.1 Interviews and personal communications

An interview conducted by the writer is a primary source, and it is cited differently from a published source. In APA, a personal interview is cited in the text only, as a personal communication, with the person's name and the date: (S. Ahmad, personal communication, 12 March 2025). It does not appear in the reference list, because the reader cannot obtain it from a library. In MLA, an interview is listed in Works Cited, with the interviewee's name, the title or description of the interview, the interviewer's name, and the date. In Chicago, an interview is usually cited in a note, with the name of the person interviewed, the date, and the place, and it may appear in the bibliography.

The difference between the styles reflects a difference in philosophy: APA treats an interview as private evidence that cannot be checked, while MLA and Chicago treat it as a source that should be documented. Whichever style is used, the writer must have the interviewee's permission to quote them, and must protect their identity where confidentiality was promised. A thesis that quotes an interviewee by name without permission has an ethical problem as well as a referencing problem.

8.2 Datasets and statistics

Datasets are increasingly cited as sources in their own right, and they should be referenced like any other publication: author or organisation, year, title, version, publisher or repository, and a DOI or web address where one exists. In APA, a dataset entry gives the author, the year, the title in italics, the version in brackets, and the publisher, with a DOI or web address. In MLA and Chicago, the pattern is similar, with the repository or the publishing organisation named.

Statistics taken from a dataset or a statistical publication should be cited to the publication that produced them, not to the website where they were found. If a figure comes from a government statistical release, the reference should name the releasing organisation and the title of the release, so that the reader can find the original table and check the figure.

8.3 Government reports and official documents

A government report is cited like a book, with the government department or agency as the author. In APA, the entry gives the agency as the author, the year, the title in italics, and the publisher, which is usually the same agency. In MLA, the agency is given as the author, followed by the title in italics and the publisher. In Chicago, the agency is given as the author, with the place of publication and the publisher.

Official documents such as laws, regulations, and policy papers follow the same pattern, with the issuing body as the author. Where a document has a number, such as a report number or a policy number, it should be included, because it helps the reader to find the exact document among many with similar titles.

8.4 Conference papers, newspapers and other media

A paper presented at a conference is cited with the author, the year, the title, the name of the conference, and the place and date. If the paper was later published in

conference proceedings, it is cited as a chapter in an edited book. A newspaper article is cited with the author, the date, the article title, the newspaper title in italics, and the page or the web address. A film is cited with the director, the year, the title in italics, and the production company. A social media post is cited with the author's name, the date, the first words of the post, the name of the platform, and the web address.

For media sources, the date matters more than for books, because a film or a post is tied to a particular moment. Give the full date where it is known, and give the web address for anything found online. A reference to a film or a post that gives only a title is useless to a reader who wants to find it.

Unusual source	How it is usually cited
Personal interview	APA: in text only. MLA/Chicago: listed, with name and date
Dataset	Author, year, title, version, repository, DOI or address
Government report	Agency as author, year, title, publisher
Conference paper	Author, year, title, conference name, place, date
Newspaper article	Author, date, article title, newspaper, page or address
Film	Director, year, title, production company
Social media post	Author, date, first words, platform, address

[ ] Interviews are cited as personal communications in APA, and listed in MLA and Chicago.

[ ] Datasets are cited with a version and a repository or DOI where available.

[ ] Government reports name the issuing agency as the author.

[ ] Media sources include the full date and a web address where relevant.

[ ] Permission has been obtained before quoting an interviewee by name.

Chapter 9: Paraphrasing and Quoting

Referencing is not only about the list at the end of the document. It is also about the way borrowed material is used in the text, and the two main ways are paraphrasing and quoting. A paraphrase restates someone else's idea in the writer's own words. A quotation reproduces someone else's exact words. Both need a citation, and both have their place. A thesis that only quotes is a collection of other people's writing. A thesis that only paraphrases may lose the force of the original. A good writer uses both, and knows when each is appropriate.

Paraphrasing is the more common of the two, and the more useful. It shows that the writer has understood the source well enough to restate it, and it allows the writer to keep control of the argument and the style. Quoting is reserved for passages where the exact words matter: a definition, a striking phrase, a claim that the writer wishes to examine closely. A thesis should contain far more paraphrase than quotation, and long quotations should be rare.

9.1 How to paraphrase well

A good paraphrase changes the words and the sentence structure, keeps the meaning, and gives a citation. It is not enough to replace a few words with synonyms and keep the rest of the sentence the same; that is patchwriting, and it is treated as plagiarism in many universities, even when a citation is given. To paraphrase well, read the passage, close the source, write the idea in your own words from memory, and then check your version against the original for accuracy.

A paraphrase should be shorter than the original or about the same length. It should not add ideas that were not in the original, and it should not change the meaning. If the original says that feedback 'may' improve accuracy, the paraphrase must not say that it 'does' improve accuracy. The citation follows the paraphrase, so that the reader knows whose idea is being restated.

9.2 How to quote well

A quotation reproduces the exact words of the source, inside quotation marks, with a citation that includes a page number. In APA, a quotation of fewer than forty words is run into the text: Ahmad (2021) states that feedback works best when it is 'specific, timely, and focused on the task' (p. 45). A quotation of forty words or more is set as a separate block, indented from the left margin, without quotation marks, with the citation after the final full stop. In MLA, the limit for a run-in quotation is four lines of prose; longer quotations are set as a block. In Chicago, the limit is five lines or one hundred words.

Every quotation must be exact, including spelling and punctuation. If a word is omitted, the omission is marked with three dots, called an ellipsis. If a word is added for clarity, it is placed in square brackets. If the original contains an error, the error is reproduced and marked with the Latin word 'sic' in square brackets, to show that the error is in the original and not in the quotation. A quotation that changes the original's words without marking the change is a misquotation, and it damages the

writer's credibility.

9.3 When to paraphrase and when to quote

• Paraphrase when the idea matters more than the exact words: most findings, arguments, and summaries.

• Quote when the exact words matter: a definition, a key term, a striking phrase, or a claim to be examined.

• Quote when the original is so well expressed that a paraphrase would weaken it.

• Paraphrase when the original is long and only part of it is relevant.

• Never quote a long passage because it is easier than paraphrasing it; that is a sign the writer has not understood the source.

Worked Example: Paraphrase, patchwriting, and quotation (fictional source)

Original: 'Feedback is most effective when it is specific, timely, and focused on the task rather than on the person.' Patchwriting (wrong): 'Feedback is most effective when it is specific, timely, and focused on the task, not the person (Ahmad, 2021).' Only two words have changed; this is still the author's sentence. Paraphrase (correct): 'Ahmad (2021) argues that feedback helps learners most when it deals with the work itself, is given promptly, and says exactly what needs to change.' Quotation (correct): 'Ahmad (2021) states that feedback is most effective when it is 'specific, timely, and focused on the task rather than on the person' (p. 45).'

[ ] Most borrowed material is paraphrased, not quoted.

[ ] A paraphrase changes the words and the sentence structure, not just a few words.

[ ] Every paraphrase carries a citation.

[ ] Every quotation is exact, with a page number.

[ ] Long quotations are set as blocks, following the rules of the style.

Chapter 10: Avoiding Plagiarism

Plagiarism is presenting someone else's words, ideas, data, or creative work as one's own, without acknowledgement. It is the most serious offence in academic writing, and it is the offence that referencing exists to prevent. A writer who cites sources properly does not plagiarise, because every borrowing is acknowledged. A writer who does not cite, or who cites badly, risks being accused of plagiarism even when they did not intend to deceive anyone. Intention matters less than the reader's experience: if the reader cannot tell what is borrowed and what is original, the writing is plagiarised in effect, whatever the writer meant.

Plagiarism takes several forms, and students should know them all. The most obvious is copying words without quotation marks or a citation. Less obvious, but equally serious, is copying ideas without a citation, even when the words have been changed. Another form is patchwriting, described in Chapter 9, in which a few words are changed but the sentence structure and the ideas remain the author's. Another is

self-plagiarism, in which a writer reuses their own earlier work without acknowledgement, for example by submitting the same essay for two courses. And another is collusion, in which two students submit work that is so similar that it cannot be independent.

10.1 Why students plagiarise, and how to avoid it

Most student plagiarism is not deliberate dishonesty. It happens because a student is under pressure, because they do not understand the rules, or because they have not kept good notes. A student who copies a passage into their notes without marking it as a quotation may later believe the words are their own. A student who writes the night before a deadline may copy a paragraph because paraphrasing takes too long. A student who does not know that ideas need citations, not only words, may paraphrase carefully and still plagiarise.

The remedy is a set of habits, not a single rule. Take notes in your own words from the start, and mark every direct quotation clearly, with the page number. Record the full reference for every source as you read it. Write the first draft from your notes, not from the sources open beside you, so that the words are yours. Leave time to check the draft against the sources. And ask for help if the rules are unclear: a supervisor would far rather explain referencing than investigate plagiarism.

10.2 What happens when plagiarism is found

Universities use software that compares a submitted document with a large database of published work and with other students' work, and that highlights passages that match. A match is not proof of plagiarism by itself; it may be a correctly cited quotation, a common phrase, or a reference list entry. But a long unmatched passage, or a pattern of matches across a document, will lead to an investigation. The student is asked to explain, and the work is examined by a panel.

The consequences depend on the seriousness of the case and on the university's rules. A first, minor case may result in a warning and a requirement to rewrite the work. A serious case may result in failure of the course, failure of the thesis, or loss of the degree. A case involving deliberate deception may result in expulsion. The consequences are severe because the offence is severe: plagiarism undermines the trust on which all academic work depends.

10.3 Using sources honestly

- Cite every idea, finding, and fact that comes from a source, not only direct quotations.
- Use quotation marks for every exact phrase of more than a few words taken from a source.
- Paraphrase by changing the words and the structure, and still cite the source.
- Do not submit the same work for two courses without permission.
- Do not copy from another student, and do not let another student copy from you.
- When in doubt, cite. A citation that turns out to be unnecessary costs nothing; a missing citation can cost a degree.

Worked Example: An honest paragraph (fictional sources)

'Peer feedback has been shown to improve writing accuracy (Ahmad, 2021), and the effect appears to be larger in small classes (Ahmad and Khan, 2021). However, students report that they value feedback most when it is specific and timely, and that vague praise is unhelpful (Raza, 2022). Taken together, these findings suggest that the design of feedback matters as much as its frequency.' Every borrowed idea carries a citation. The final sentence is the writer's own conclusion, drawn from the cited findings, and it needs no citation because it is an original judgement. A reader can tell at a glance which ideas are borrowed and which are the writer's own.

[ ] Every borrowed idea, not only every quotation, carries a citation.

[ ] Direct quotations are in quotation marks with a page number.

[ ] Notes mark quotations clearly, with page numbers, so they cannot be mistaken for my own words.

[ ] I have not reused my own earlier work without acknowledgement.

[ ] I understand the consequences of plagiarism at my university.

Chapter 11: Reference Managers

A reference manager is a software tool that stores the details of sources, formats citations and reference lists, and keeps the in-text citations and the list in agreement. Common tools of this kind are widely used in universities, and most are free for students or available through a university licence. A reference manager does not remove the need to understand referencing: the writer must still choose the right style, check that the details are correct, and decide what to cite. But it removes the mechanical work of formatting entries and checking that every citation has a matching reference, and it saves hours on a long thesis.

The basic workflow is the same in every reference manager. The writer saves a source to a library, either by importing it from a database or a library catalogue, or by entering the details by hand. While writing, the writer inserts a citation from the library into the text, using a small add-in in the word processor. The software formats the citation in the chosen style and adds the entry to the reference list. If the writer changes the style, for example from APA to MLA, the software reformats every citation and every entry at once.

11.1 What a reference manager can do

A reference manager can store hundreds or thousands of sources, organise them into folders by chapter or by topic, and search them by author, title, or keyword. It can import details directly from academic databases, which reduces typing errors. It can format citations and reference lists in hundreds of styles, and it can switch between styles in seconds. It can find duplicate entries, attach the full text of an article to its record, and share a library with a supervisor or a research group. For a thesis with a hundred references, these functions are not luxuries; they are the difference between a consistent list and a list full of errors.

A reference manager can also help with the writing itself. A writer who has organised sources by theme can see at a glance which sources support each chapter. A writer who has attached notes to each source can return to their own summary of a paper without re-reading it. And a writer who has stored the full text can search across all their sources for a term, which is useful when checking a claim or finding a quotation.

11.2 What a reference manager cannot do

A reference manager cannot decide which sources to cite, and it cannot judge whether a citation is needed. It cannot check that the details it imported are correct: databases often supply incomplete or incorrect details, especially for web pages and for sources in languages other than English, and the writer must check each record against the source itself. It cannot fix a citation that points to the wrong source, and it cannot tell the difference between two works by the same author in the same year, unless the writer has told it how to distinguish them.

A reference manager also cannot protect a writer from plagiarism. It can format a citation correctly, but only the writer can decide where a citation is needed. A thesis written with a reference manager can still contain uncited borrowings, and a thesis written without one can be perfectly referenced. The software is a tool, not a substitute for understanding.

11.3 Using a reference manager well

- Choose one tool and learn it properly, rather than switching between tools.
- Check every imported record against the source itself before you cite it.
- Organise sources into folders by chapter or by theme as you read, not at the end.
- Back up the library regularly, and keep a copy separate from the computer.
- Before submission, check the formatted list by eye: software makes mistakes, especially with unusual sources.
- Make sure the style selected in the software is the exact style your department requires, including the edition.

A final warning: do not leave learning the software until the last week of the thesis. A reference manager is most useful when it is used from the first week of reading, so that every source is stored as it is read. A writer who tries to enter a hundred sources in the final week will make errors under pressure, and will lose the time the software was meant to save.

[ ] I have chosen one reference manager and learned its basic functions.

[ ] Every record in my library has been checked against the source itself.

[ ] Sources are organised by chapter or theme.

[ ] The selected style is the exact style and edition my department requires.

[ ] The library is backed up, with a copy kept separately.

[ ] I will check the final formatted list by eye before submission.

Chapter 12: Common Errors and a Checklist

Most referencing errors are small, repeated, and easy to prevent once they have been named. This chapter collects the errors that appear most often in student theses, explains why each one matters, and gives the correction. Read it with your own reference list in front of you, and check each error against your own work. An examiner who finds three or four of these errors in the first pages of a reference list will read the rest of the thesis expecting more.

12.1 The most common errors

- A citation in the text with no entry in the reference list, or an entry in the list that is never cited.
- The author's name spelled differently in the text and in the list, so the two cannot be matched.
- The year in the text differing from the year in the list.
- Two styles mixed in one document, for example APA in-text citations with an MLA Works Cited list.
- Titles in the wrong case: sentence case where title case is required, or the reverse.
- Italics missing from book and journal titles, or applied to article titles that should be in plain text.
- A missing DOI or web address for an online source, or a web address that no longer works.
- Page ranges missing from journal articles and from chapters in edited books.
- The word 'et al.' used incorrectly, for example for two authors, or without a full stop.
- A web page cited by its address alone, with no author, title, or date.
- Sources listed in the wrong order, or not in alphabetical order at all.
- A reference copied from another paper without checking it against the original source.

12.2 Why these errors matter

Each of these errors has the same effect: it makes the reader's job harder. A citation without a list entry sends the reader to a dead end. A misspelled name makes the source unfindable. A missing page range forces the reader to search a whole journal issue. A mixed style tells the reader that the writer did not care enough to be consistent. None of these errors is difficult to fix, and that is exactly why examiners notice them: they are evidence of carelessness, and carelessness in referencing suggests carelessness elsewhere.

The most damaging error in the list is the last one: copying a reference from another paper without checking it. References copied in this way often contain errors that have been passed from paper to paper, and they sometimes cite sources that do not exist or that say something different from what the writer claims. Always check a

reference against the original source, or against the publisher's own page for the source, before citing it.

Worked Example: Finding the errors

A student writes in the text: 'Peer feedback improves accuracy (Ahmed, 2021).' The reference list gives: 'Ahmad, S. (2021). The craft of feedback. City Press.' Two errors are visible at once: the surname is spelled 'Ahmed' in the text and 'Ahmad' in the list, so the reader cannot be sure they are the same person; and the book title is in sentence case, which is correct in APA but would be wrong in MLA. A two-part check, matching each citation to its entry, would catch the spelling error in seconds.

12.3 The final checklist

[ ] Every in-text citation has a matching entry, and every entry is cited.

[ ] Author names and years match between the text and the list.

[ ] One style is used throughout, in the correct edition.

[ ] Titles use the correct capitalisation and the correct use of italics.

[ ] Journal entries include volume, issue, page range and DOI where available.

[ ] Web entries include an author or organisation, a date, and a working address.

[ ] The list is in alphabetical order by the first author's surname.

[ ] Every reference has been checked against the original source.

[ ] Direct quotations have page numbers.

[ ] The list is headed correctly: 'References', 'Works Cited', or 'Bibliography'.

Chapter 13: Worked Examples

This chapter brings the whole guide together with worked examples. Each example takes one source and shows how it is cited in the text and in the reference list in all three styles, so that the differences between the styles can be seen directly. The examples use fictional authors and titles, so that no real publication is misrepresented. The patterns are the point: learn the pattern, and any real source can be cited by following it.

Work through the examples with a source of your own beside you. For each source, write the in-text citation and the list entry in your chosen style, and then check your work against the pattern. If your entry differs from the pattern, find the reason: a missing detail, a wrong capitalisation, or a detail in the wrong order. Correct it, and the pattern will soon become automatic.

13.1 Example one: a book by one author

The source is a fictional book: a single author, published in 2021, with a publisher and a place of publication. It is the simplest case, and it shows the basic shape of each style most clearly.

Worked Example: A book by one author (fictional)

In-text, APA: 'Peer feedback improves accuracy (Ahmad, 2021).' List, APA: 'Ahmad, S. (2021). The craft of feedback. City Press.' In-text, MLA: 'Peer feedback improves accuracy (Ahmad 45).' List, MLA: 'Ahmad, Sara. The Craft of Feedback. City Press, 2021.' In-text, Chicago author-date: 'Peer feedback improves accuracy (Ahmad 2021, 45).' List, Chicago: 'Ahmad, Sara. 2021. The Craft of Feedback. Lahore: City Press.' In-text, Chicago notes: a raised number, with a footnote: 'Sara Ahmad, The Craft of Feedback (Lahore: City Press, 2021), 45.' Bibliography: 'Ahmad, Sara. The Craft of Feedback. Lahore: City Press, 2021.'

13.2 Example two: a journal article

The source is a fictional journal article: two authors, published in a journal with a volume and an issue number, with a page range and a DOI. It shows how the three styles handle the extra details that a journal article requires.

Worked Example: A journal article (fictional)

In-text, APA: 'The effect was larger in small classes (Ahmad and Khan, 2021).' List, APA: 'Ahmad, S., and Khan, A. (2021). Peer feedback in secondary classrooms. Journal of Teaching Practice, 14(2), 112-128. https://doi.org/10.0000/example.' In-text, MLA: 'The effect was larger in small classes (Ahmad and Khan 112).' List, MLA: 'Ahmad, Sara, and Ali Khan. "Peer Feedback in Secondary Classrooms." Journal of Teaching Practice, vol. 14, no. 2, 2021, pp. 112-128. https://doi.org/10.0000/example.' In-text, Chicago author-date: 'The effect was larger in small classes (Ahmad and Khan 2021, 112).' List, Chicago: 'Ahmad, Sara, and Ali Khan. 2021. "Peer Feedback in Secondary Classrooms." Journal of Teaching Practice 14 (2): 112-128. https://doi.org/10.0000/example.' Note the DOI: it is given as a full web address in all three styles, so that the reader can reach the article directly. The DOI shown is a placeholder for illustration; a real entry uses the real DOI of the real article.

13.3 Example three: a chapter in an edited book

The source is a fictional chapter in an edited book: a chapter author, an editor, a book title, and a page range. It shows how the three styles handle a source that is part of a larger work.

Worked Example: A chapter in an edited book (fictional)

In-text, APA: 'Teachers need training in giving feedback (Raza, 2022).' List, APA: 'Raza, F. (2022). Training teachers to give feedback. In S. Ahmad (Ed.), Feedback in the classroom (pp. 78-95). City Press.' In-text, MLA: 'Teachers need training in giving feedback (Raza 78).' List, MLA: 'Raza, Fatima. "Training Teachers to Give Feedback." Feedback in the Classroom, edited by Sara Ahmad, City Press, 2022, pp. 78-95.' In-text, Chicago author-date: 'Teachers need training in giving feedback (Raza 2022, 78).' List, Chicago: 'Raza, Fatima. 2022. "Training Teachers to Give Feedback." In Feedback in the Classroom, edited by Sara Ahmad, 78-95. Lahore: City Press.'

13.4 Example four: a web page with no named author

The source is a fictional web page published by an organisation, with no named

author and a date of publication. It shows how the three styles handle a source with a missing author, which is the commonest difficulty with web sources.

Worked Example: A web page with no named author (fictional)

In-text, APA: 'The guidance recommends weekly feedback (Ministry of Education, 2023).' List, APA: 'Ministry of Education. (2023). Guidance on classroom feedback. https://www.example.gov/feedback.' In-text, MLA: 'The guidance recommends weekly feedback (Ministry of Education).' List, MLA: 'Ministry of Education. Guidance on Classroom Feedback. 2023, www.example.gov/feedback.' In-text, Chicago author-date: 'The guidance recommends weekly feedback (Ministry of Education 2023).' List, Chicago: 'Ministry of Education. 2023. Guidance on Classroom Feedback. https://www.example.gov/feedback.' The organisation is used as the author in all three styles. The web address is a placeholder for illustration; a real entry uses the real address of the real page.

Source	APA in-text	MLA in-text	Chicago author-date
Book, one author	(Ahmad, 2021)	(Ahmad 45)	(Ahmad 2021, 45)
Article, two authors	(Ahmad and Khan, 2021)	(Ahmad and Khan 112)	(Ahmad and Khan 2021, 112)
Chapter, one author	(Raza, 2022)	(Raza 78)	(Raza 2022, 78)
Web page, organisation	(Ministry of Education, 2023)	(Ministry of Education)	(Ministry of Education 2023)

- [ ] I can cite a book, an article, a chapter and a web page in my chosen style.
- [ ] I can explain the difference between the three styles for the same source.
- [ ] I know how to handle a source with no named author.
- [ ] I know how to handle a source with no date.
- [ ] My own entries follow the patterns in these examples.

Chapter 14: Conclusion

Referencing is a skill, not a talent, and it is learned the same way as any other skill: by understanding the principles, practising the patterns, and checking the work. The principles are simple. Every borrowing is acknowledged. Every in-text citation has a matching entry in the list, and every entry is cited in the text. One style is used throughout, in the correct edition. The patterns for the common sources are few, and once they are learned, almost every source can be cited by following them.

The habits matter as much as the rules. Record the full details of every source as you read it. Organise your sources as you go, whether on cards, in a document, or in a reference manager. Write from your notes in your own words, and cite as you write, not at the end. Check the two-part match between the text and the list before submission, and read the list by eye one last time. These habits take a little time at the start of a project and save a great deal of time at the end.

Above all, remember why referencing exists. It is not a set of rules invented to trouble students. It is the mechanism by which scholarship stays honest, by which a reader can check a claim, and by which a writer gives credit to the people whose work made their own possible. A thesis with clear, consistent references tells the examiner that the writer is careful, honest, and ready to be checked. That is a reputation worth having, and it begins with a single citation, correctly written. Good luck with your referencing, and with the research behind it.

Suggested Reading

The following are general, well-known types of works that students commonly consult when learning to reference and to write academically. Check your university library for the latest editions, and follow your department's guidance on referencing style.

- The official APA Publication Manual: the authoritative source for APA 7th edition rules on in-text citations, reference lists, and the overall format of a paper.
- The official MLA Handbook: the authoritative source for MLA 9th edition rules, including the core elements system and the Works Cited list.
- The official Chicago Manual of Style: the authoritative source for Chicago 17th edition rules, covering both the notes and bibliography system and the author-date system.
- General research methods textbooks: standard methodology texts used in most universities explain research design and writing up, and usually include a chapter on referencing and avoiding plagiarism.
- Academic writing guides: widely used guides to writing theses and dissertations explain structure, argument and style, with examples of correct referencing in context.
- Your university's thesis regulations and referencing guide: always the first and final authority on which style, which edition, and which format your thesis must follow.
- Your supervisor's recommended reading list for your subject: the most relevant

source of all, because it is chosen for your specific topic and method.